

Just another story

Suhas

"Arranged marriages in India aren't broken." - he said, looking down at his cup of tea on the terrace of a balmy summer evening.

His black glasses, a few days old beard, and short hair gave him that aura of a learned guy.

"They're not?" - I asked him, half puzzled and half unconvinced.

He glanced up from his cup, the warm glow from the setting sun reflecting off his glasses. "No," he said slowly, pausing as if to collect his thoughts. "It's more a question of understanding and acceptance. The premise is not about romantic love but rather about a partnership, about growing together. Sometimes, it works; sometimes, it doesn't. But they're not inherently 'broken.'"

"Wait, what?" I said, blinking at him. "So you're saying it's all about the agreement? The shared goals and compatibility?"

He leaned back, his gaze returning to the swirling tea in his cup. While he was lost deep in thought, I couldn't help but notice a neatly folded letter starting with the words "Dear Ira" half tucked in the front pouch of his backpack. A faint smile touched his lips, but his eyes were distant, lost in thought. Who is this Ira, who seems to be very dear to him? Was that even an actual name?

His neatly ironed white shirt was getting crumpled as he leaned against the coconut tree while he stood there talking to me. He had come to take a look at me - the potential bride for him after both of us had given the green light for the marriage talks to begin.

"Well," he started, the corners of his mouth lifting into a faint smile. "Isn't that what all good relationships are about?"

He seemed to be in no rush to leave, standing under the tree, sipping his tea, and pondering life's intricacies. His casual, almost scholarly demeanor made me question my preconceived notions about this arranged marriage scenario.

"But what about love?" I asked, unable to hide the skepticism from my voice. "Does love fit anywhere in this equation of yours? Or is it just about compatibility and shared goals?"

He chuckled - his eyes crinkling at the corners. "Love," he began, as he glanced up at the now darkening sky, "...can grow both with time and shared experiences. Sometimes, it may not be there initially, but that doesn't mean it never does. It can develop. And isn't marriage more fulfilling when built on mutual respect and understanding rather than just a momentary feeling?"

I wasn't convinced and had a feeling he had more to say. Perhaps some experiences? Maybe an ex-girlfriend?

I looked at him, my brows furrowing slightly as I tried to read between the lines. "You seem to speak from experience," I finally said, my curiosity piqued. "Is there... someone

else? An ex-girlfriend, perhaps?" I patted myself for not saying Ira's name out loud lest it caused some awkwardness on our first meeting.

He took off his glasses, rubbing the bridge of his nose for a moment. He seemed taken aback. After a pause, he nodded, "There was someone, yes. But that's a story for another day, perhaps when we know each other better. Right now, let's just say I've come to value companionship over initial sparks."

"But how can a person see a handsome guy with a good pay package on a matrimony site, think he's husband material, and just agree to be married to him for the rest of their lives?" - I was asking more questions than I've asked in my JEE coaching.

He laughed, the sound echoing in the quiet evening. "It's certainly not that simple," he agreed. "Trust me. I totally get your point of view. It's not just a pretty face or a good job. It's about getting to know someone, understanding their values, aspirations, and, of course, their quirks. That's why we have this period of courtship before marriage, isn't it? We're not just blindly saying 'yes' to this lifelong commitment. We're saying 'yes' to the opportunity to get to know each other and see if it's going to work out."

I had to admit. He made sense. He was making me think and question my own beliefs. But I still wasn't entirely sure if I was ready to take the leap.

He seemed to sense my unease and smiled kindly, his gaze softening. "It's okay to have doubts and questions," he said. "In fact, it's necessary. But remember, in any form of relationship - be it love or arranged marriage - there's always a risk. And there's always a chance it might not work out. But that's the beauty of it, isn't it? It's a leap of faith, a hope for a shared future."

I looked at him, and for the first time, I saw a flicker of uncertainty in his eyes. It made him seem more relatable.

"Take your time," he said, standing up from his spot under the coconut tree. "Think about it. And remember, I'm here if you want to talk or have more questions. Marriage is a big decision, after all."

With that, he started walking down the flight of stairs, leaving me with my thoughts and the faint aroma of his cardamom-infused tea. I had a lot to think about and consider, and of course, spam my girls' group with the story of meeting this guy and his quirky, bookish charm. But one thing was certain: this arranged marriage scenario was more complex and intriguing than I had initially thought.

"How was he so sure that I was the one he wanted to get married to? He spoke like the ball was in my court, and he was convinced of his decision," - I questioned Anvi, my classmate from college who I'd grown up with.

"Aren't guys like that? They fall in love first and then figure out the rest later!" she giggled.

"Well, that's quite a generalization," I responded with a light laugh, rolling my eyes at Anvi's jest. "But it did seem like he was quite certain about this. I wonder if it's the same for all guys or just him?"

Anvi shrugged her shoulders, her eyes gleaming with curiosity. "Maybe he's the kind who knows what he wants and goes for it? Or perhaps he's just really good at making decisions?"

"But what about love? How can he be so sure about something like that?" I questioned, my thoughts going back to our conversation. "I mean, it takes me hours to decide on a dress, let alone a life partner."

"Maybe love isn't a prerequisite for him? Perhaps he sees marriage more as a partnership or companionship and believes love can grow from that." Anvi suggested, taking a bite of her midnight Maggi - sitting at the same spot on the terrace he was at a few hours back.

I nodded, deep in thought. There was wisdom in his words, a refreshing perspective on the idea of marriage. But it also raised multiple questions. I was unsure if I was ready to change my perception of love and marriage so drastically.

"Or, maybe he's already started developing feelings for you, and he's more sure about it than you are," Anvi added with a teasing grin, her eyes twinkling mischievously. I threw a cushion at her playfully but couldn't help but blush at the thought.

"Only time will tell, I suppose." I sighed, taking a deep breath. I knew I had a lot to think about, a lot to decide. But for now, I decided to let things unfold naturally and see where this journey takes me.

I glanced at the screen, a small smile playing on my lips as I recognized the sender. "It's him," I confessed, showing Anvi the text. "He's asking about my plans for the weekend."

Anvi's eyes widened in excitement. "What are you going to reply?" she asked eagerly.

"I'm not sure," I admitted, chewing on my lower lip as I thought about my response. "I don't want to seem too eager, but I also don't want to appear uninterested."

"Why not just be honest?" Anvi suggested. "If you have plans, tell him. If you don't, maybe this is an opportunity to get to know him better."

I nodded, considering her words. Finally, I typed a reply. "No plans yet. How about you?" I hit send before I could second-guess myself.

I looked up at Anvi, shrugging nonchalantly. "Let's see what happens."

But deep down, I was curious to see where this would lead. Perhaps this arranged marriage scenario wasn't so bad after all. Maybe this courtship before marriage, an arranged-love marriage, if I could call it, could be the best?

Only time will tell.

Anvi and I sat on the terrace for a long time, discussing life, love, marriage, and, of course, the man who had suddenly become a significant character in my narrative. Anvi,

being the hopeless romantic she is, was already planning the wedding, her eyes shining with anticipation. On the other hand, I was still absorbing the enormity of the situation.

As they say, love was something Anvi and I have longed for since time immemorial. But finding the right guy admittedly has been a struggle. "Where are all the good guys, Shraddha?" - she would ask me. And those we've had a crush on have crushes on others, and neither of us has actually come around to ask them out. A few have proposed going on a date with us. Still, it has yet to go anywhere, so much for the talk with the potential groom about shared interests and compatibility. It says something about both of us.

A week later, we met again. Not on a terrace, and not under the mild supervision of parents pretending not to listen, but in a small café pressed between a stationery shop and a dentist's clinic. The kind of place where the menu was handwritten and the tables protested if you leaned on them too confidently.

He arrived before me. I knew because when I walked in, he was already looking at the door, his fingers circling the rim of his coffee cup as though rehearsing patience.

"You look different," I said, once we'd sat down.

He smiled, cautious. "Better different or suspicious different?"

"Cleaner," I said. "You shaved."

He reached for his face instinctively. "Didn't want to look too philosophical today."

That made me laugh. And just like that, the stiffness that had accompanied us from the terrace loosened its grip.

"So," he said, stirring his coffee though there was nothing in it, "tell me something your parents don't know about you."

"That's a dangerous question."

"We're already here," he said, gesturing vaguely around us. "Might as well be honest."

We spoke for longer than we meant to. About things that mattered and things that didn't. He admitted he disliked his job despite the comfort it afforded him. I confessed that I could burn water if left unattended. He liked old Kishore Kumar songs. I preferred silence to music. He read philosophy books but rarely finished them. I collected notebooks I never wrote in.

When we stood up to leave, it felt abrupt, like stopping in the middle of a sentence.

He offered to drop me home. On his bike. An old Honda Activa that had clearly lived several lives before this one.

"Very glamorous," I said, climbing on.

"It has character," he replied. "Like me."

As traffic crawled forward, my hands resting lightly on the edge of the seat, I thought: this feels easy. Not exciting. Not cinematic. Just unforced.

We met again after that. And again. Cafés began to blur into one another. Parks acquired benches we favored. In bookstores, he lingered where I grew impatient. Once, at his apartment, he insisted on cooking dal. It boiled over while he spoke, and he didn't notice. I turned the stove off.

It didn't feel like falling in love. It felt like learning someone's presence. The way one learns the sound a ceiling fan makes at night.

One evening, walking through Cubbon Park, he told me about Ira.

"We worked together," he said, hands buried in his pockets. "I asked her out once. She said no."

"And then?"

"She got married."

He kept walking. I matched his pace.

"I used to think about her a lot," he said. "Mostly about what could've been."

I waited.

"I think," he added after a while, "I miss the idea of her more than the person."

That made sense in a way I didn't want to examine too closely.

By the third month, questions began arriving at home, sharper and less patient.

"So?" my mother asked one afternoon, cutting vegetables with unnecessary force. "What do you think?"

"I'm still thinking."

"How long will you think?"

I didn't know. I only knew that I wasn't unhappy. And that certainty still felt like something other people possessed more easily.

When I told him about the pressure, he nodded.

"My mother's already asking for dates," he said. "I told her I'm waiting."

"For what?"

“For you.”

There was no drama in the way he said it. No insistence. Just a statement, as though he had already rearranged something in his life and didn’t expect applause for it.

“I decided a while ago,” he added.

“When?”

“Somewhere between your terrible upma,” he said, smiling, “and that argument about my mother visiting.”

I laughed despite myself. “I’m scared,” I said.

“So am I,” he replied. “But I think we could be good at this. Not perfect. Just... steady.”

I said yes a week later. Not confidently. Not joyfully. Just honestly.

The engagement was loud. Relatives everywhere. Opinions everywhere. Everyone asking if I was happy.

I said yes. Because I was. Mostly.

Marriage followed quickly. December. Too many rituals. Too much food. Too many tears. Too much kajal.

When it was finally over, we sat in our new apartment, still dressed in wedding clothes, exhausted.

“We did it,” I said.

“We started it,” he corrected.

The months that followed were quiet. Almost disappointingly so. Mornings settled into patterns. Evenings dissolved into dinners and television and the glow of phones. We learned each other’s habits. Some endearing. Some irritating. He folded his clothes immediately. I left mine on chairs with vague intentions. He woke early. I didn’t. We negotiated space without naming it.

One Sunday morning, the gas ran out while I was cooking. Frustrated, I turned the stove knob harder than necessary. His phone buzzed on the counter.

I didn’t mean to look. But I did.

Ira.

I sat down on the kitchen floor before he returned.

When he did, he understood without asking.

“I didn’t reply,” he said.

"I know."

"That doesn't make it better."

"No."

We sat across from each other. The space between us felt larger than the room.

"Do you still think about her?" I asked.

He didn't answer immediately. The silence stretched.

"Yes," he said finally. "Sometimes."

My chest tightened.

"But not in the way you're afraid of," he continued. "I think about the person I was when I needed certainty from someone else."

I watched him tear a tomato leaf absently.

"She texted," he said. "And I realized I had nothing to say back."

Later that night, I asked him to delete her number.

He did. Without ceremony.

Life resumed its rhythm. Work. Dinner. Small disagreements. Small victories.

One evening, sitting on the balcony with a badly made baingan ka bharta, he said, "This is terrible."

"It really is."

"Pizza?"

"Yes."

But we finished the bharta anyway. That was when it occurred to me that love hadn't arrived with declarations or clarity. It had slipped in quietly. Through irritation. Through forgiveness. Through the decision to stay when it would've been easier to withdraw.

Later, lying beside him, I thought of that first evening on the terrace. The tea. The letter half-hidden in his bag. The certainty he spoke of too early.

Arranged marriages aren't broken.

They're unfinished stories. Ones you agree to write together, without knowing how many pages it will take. And perhaps that is the point.